Unlocking Potential: The Impact of Education on Incarcerated Individuals

Issue Analysis Paper

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According to Robinson (2025), the United States' prison system has been in place for over two centuries. Different views on punishment, deterrence, and rehabilitation have shaped its development over time. The study also highlights that debates about crime and punishment must consider these core ideas, as they have evolved alongside significant political and demographic changes.

Data from the author indicates that, between 1880 and 1975, the combined state and federal prison populations stayed below 250,000. However, the "war on crime" efforts in the 1960s and 1970s, along with harsher sentencing laws in the 1980s and 1990s, led to a rapid rise in the prison population, reaching 2.3 million inmates by 2018. In 2024, nearly 1.9 million people were believed to be incarcerated, making the U.S. the country with the largest prison population worldwide.

As the system grew, policymakers and correctional leaders increasingly focused on programs, especially education, to support rehabilitation and improve reentry prospects. In this context, higher education in prisons has become a vital yet often debated area. College-in-prison programs are influenced by changing federal policies, particularly the availability of Pell Grants, as well as differences in state funding, institutional priorities, and public opinion (Conway & Lally, 2025).

Research consistently shows that participation in correctional education reduces recidivism and improves post-release outcomes (Patterson, 2022). However, access to these programs remains unequal and unfair, hindered by disabilities, digital literacy gaps, prison restrictions, and capacity challenges.

Meanwhile, recent research emphasizes the deeply human aspects of learning in prison, such as identity development, increased confidence, community building, and transformative teaching relationships (Abeyta, 2022; Holder et al., 2023; Ronda & Rose, 2024). However, the lived experiences and meaning-making of incarcerated and formerly incarcerated students remain underrepresented in research, which negatively impacts higher education's understanding of what truly makes prison education meaningful. This study reviews relevant literature to provide context and identify some gaps for future research.

Research Purpose

This paper aims to systematically review selected research on higher education in prisons, focusing on how incarcerated and formerly incarcerated students experience learning, which aspects of these educational experiences they find most meaningful or transformative, and how structural, relational, and institutional factors influence access to and participation in these educational opportunities. The paper provides a foundation for further exploration of issues related to higher education for incarcerated learners.

Statement of Significance

This topic is crucial in higher education and has policy implications. First, understanding incarcerated students' experiences can help colleges and administrators improve programs within correctional facilities and develop systems that support learners in restricted environments. Second, knowledge about incarcerated students' experiences will guide curriculum and teaching practices, helping faculty adapt instructional methods for settings affected by trauma, limited technology, and carceral restrictions.

Third, it has immediate implications for student support and campus inclusion as more formerly incarcerated students enroll in colleges after release. Understanding what supported

their learning in prison can help institutions develop more inclusive advising, reentry programs, and anti-stigma initiatives. Additionally, this review will help identify prison education not just as a way to reduce recidivism but as an essential part of promoting equity, restorative practices, and institutional accountability in higher education. Finally, the paper provides evidence of effective pedagogical strategies for incarcerated learners that may be useful for policymakers.

The rest of the paper is structured as follows: definitions and the literature review are in Section 2. Section 3 covers the discussion. The conclusion appears in Section 4.

Definitions

Correctional education refers to educational programs offered to incarcerated individuals, including basic literacy, high school equivalency, vocational training, and college-level courses (Patterson, 2022; Conway & Lally, 2025). It aims to improve literacy, vocational skills, cognitive development, and social reintegration.

Higher Education in Prison refers to postsecondary education, including associate, bachelor's, and technical programs, offered within correctional facilities (Conway & Lally, 2025; Holder et al., 2023). Federal and state policies, institutional support, and societal perceptions of incarcerated learners influence these programs.

Carceral capital refers to the skills, resilience, social networks, and cultural strengths developed during incarceration, which individuals use to succeed academically and reintegrate into society (Abeyta, 2022). The concept emphasizes a strengths-based approach to understanding the abilities of formerly incarcerated students.

Institutional support includes services, resources, and practices provided by colleges and universities to help incarcerated or formerly incarcerated students succeed, such as tutoring,

academic advising, counseling, mentorship, trauma-informed programming, and culturally responsive pedagogy (Colbert, 2025; Ronda & Rose, 2024).

Recidivism is the tendency of formerly incarcerated individuals to re-offend or go back to prison. Participation in correctional and higher education has been scientifically linked to lower recidivism rates (Patterson, 2022).

Trauma-Informed Education involves teaching methods that recognize and address the trauma backgrounds of incarcerated students, encouraging safety, emotional regulation, and engagement in learning (Phillips & Kwon, 2022; Terry & Miller, 2024)

Equity in prison education means providing fair and inclusive access to educational opportunities for all incarcerated individuals, regardless of race, gender, disability, or previous educational background (Colbert, 2025; Holder et al., 2023). Equity tackles structural barriers, policy limits, and stigma that hinder participation.

Second Chance Pell is a federal program that, after 2016, restored Pell Grant eligibility for incarcerated students in specific programs, aiming to increase access to postsecondary education and support reintegration (Conway & Lally, 2025; Thouin, 2021).Correctional Education Staff Roles describe the influence and involvement of prison staff, such as officers, educators, and mentors, in supporting both formal and informal learning experiences for incarcerated individuals (Eide & Westrheim, 2023).

Literature Review

Review Approach

The approach used in this study is a systematic review to achieve the research goal. This literature review examines educational experiences, barriers, and supports that impact incarcerated and formerly incarcerated students in higher education, based on peer-reviewed

work published from 2021 to 2025. The review focuses on studies related to postsecondary education participation, career development, and reentry assistance for justice-impacted learners.

Relevant publications were identified through systematic searches of ERIC, Medline, the Wiley Online Library, and the Teachers College databases. Search terms included prison education, correctional education, incarcerated students, formerly incarcerated students, career readiness, and reentry support. The initial search yielded a broad set of articles; after applying inclusion criteria, the resulting set focused on peer-reviewed journal articles about higher education access, student experience, or reentry outcomes. Twelve studies met the final analysis criteria.

Each article was read in full and categorized according to its primary focus

- Access and policy
- Educational outcomes and recidivism,
- Career readiness and personal development, and
- Institutional support and post-secondary success.

These broad themes are captured in the sections below.

Educational Outcomes and the Lived Experience of Learning in Prison

This important area of scholarship examines the academic and personal outcomes associated with participation in higher education while incarcerated. Patterson (2022) demonstrates that basic and postsecondary education reduces recidivism, but other researchers highlight that the most meaningful impacts extend beyond measurable recidivism results. Abeyta (2022) and Colbert (2025) show that formerly incarcerated students experience growth in

confidence, academic identity, persistence, and self-efficacy, mainly when supported by wraparound services such as tutoring, counseling, and inclusive learning environments.

Similarly, Holder et al. (2023) find that incarcerated students demonstrate career readiness comparable to that of their non-incarcerated peers, reflecting not only the rigor of prison education programs but also learners' motivation and resilience. Studies such as Ronda and Rose (2024) and Castro (2024) show that structured reentry programs, peer mentoring, trauma-informed practices, and wraparound services significantly improve post-release outcomes and educational and career opportunities.

These findings emphasize the interconnected nature of academic success and the emotional, relational, and structural supports within correctional education. While students' experiences reveal the meaningful and transformative aspects of higher education in prison, the literature also shows that these experiences are shaped, sometimes constrained by broader access, policy, and structural conditions.

Access, Policy, and Structural Conditions Shaping Educational Experiences

A significant portion of the literature explores how federal and state policies, funding systems, and institutional capacities influence access to higher education in prison. Conway and Lally (2025) and Thouin (2021) show that the availability of college-in-prison programs depends directly on political climates, Pell Grant eligibility, and varying levels of institutional and philanthropic support. These studies highlight how the changing policy environment creates unstable opportunities for incarcerated learners, often leading to program expansion during times of political support and contraction when funding or ideological backing decreases.

Barriers to participation also influence the experiences of incarcerated students. Patterson (2022) finds that while educational progress decreases recidivism, learners often encounter

challenges such as disabilities, low digital literacy, limited course options, and correctional restrictions. These obstacles not only limit who can access higher education but also impact how students view and manage their educational journeys.

Meaningful engagement in higher education requires steady funding, ongoing institutional support, and policies that promote educational opportunities and access instead of punitive restrictions. Steady funding comes from a mix of federal aid, state support, philanthropic grants, and institutional resources, helping distribute risk so programs are not solely dependent on changing political climates.

Relational, Informal, and Non-Academic Dimensions of Learning

A third body of literature emphasizes the informal, relational, and family-centered aspects of prison education. Eide and Westrheim (2023) demonstrate that correctional officers can unexpectedly facilitate informal learning by providing guidance and motivation that influence students' engagement. This work challenges traditional views of prison power dynamics by illustrating how everyday interactions contribute to educational persistence.

Research on programs for incarcerated parents offers further insight into the emotional and developmental effects of learning. Phillips and Kwon (2022) and Terry and Miller (2024) illustrate that parenting and literacy programs enhance family bonds, emotional health, and intergenerational learning. These outcomes go beyond academic success and highlight the holistic nature of educational change in carceral environments.

These studies collectively demonstrate that incarcerated learners' experiences are shaped not only by the formal curriculum but also by personal relationships, family dynamics, trauma histories, and institutional culture. These findings essentially address this study's primary goal of identifying which aspects of education participants find most meaningful and transformative.

Gaps, Limitations, and Emerging Directions in Literature

Throughout the literature, various limitations and gaps are consistently acknowledged. Methodologically, much of the research relies on qualitative approaches that focus on student narratives and lived experiences (Abeyta, 2022; Colbert, 2025). While these methods provide valuable insights into meaning-making, they limit generalizability. Quantitative studies examining long-term outcomes, program scalability, and post-release trajectories are still limited (Patterson, 2022; Holder et al., 2023). This methodological imbalance underscores a broader challenge in higher education and applied education research, where evaluative frameworks lack consistency and empirical data on program effectiveness are scattered.

The literature also highlights conceptual gaps, especially regarding equity and the specific needs of marginalized groups. Few studies explore differences across race, gender identity, disability status, and linguistic background (Colbert, 2025; Conway & Lally, 2025). The idea of carceral capital, including resilience, networks, and cultural knowledge that students draw on during incarceration, is emerging but still underdeveloped. More research is needed to understand how institutions can utilize carceral capital to develop inclusive, culturally sustaining prison education programs.

Finally, although research often emphasizes recidivism and employment, several scholars warn that focusing only on these metrics might restrict the broader educational experience (Castro, 2024; Davis & Michaels, 2015). An increasing body of research advocates for highlighting student voices and broadening evaluation methods to include humanizing, relational, and transformative aspects of learning. This change directly aligns with the study's goal of showing how formerly incarcerated students interpret and describe their experiences in higher education during incarceration.

Discussion

In all, higher education in prisons offers much more than just a chance to reduce reoffending. For many individuals, it becomes a meaningful learning experience that builds confidence, strength, and purpose. Although students in prison often face challenges such as limited resources, inconsistent support, and changing policies, education programs still make a real difference in their academic, personal, and social growth.

These insights emphasize key responsibilities for colleges, universities, and organizations that offer education in prisons. Programs require consistent funding, strong partnerships, and dependable systems to operate effectively. The learning environment should be trauma-informed, culturally responsive, and student-centered. Instructors also need proper preparation and ongoing support to teach effectively in correctional settings. Staff who assist with advising, counseling, and reentry support are crucial in helping students connect their education inside prison with opportunities after release. With Pell Grant access now available, institutions must also plan carefully to ensure programs remain stable and accessible.

Prison education is most effective when it combines high expectations with compassion. High expectations include tracking student progress, understanding access disparities, and creating learning experiences that reflect the diverse realities of those impacted by the justice system. Compassion involves recognizing students' strengths, goals, and lived experiences. When these elements come together, prison education can open doors, support personal growth, and foster more inclusive and supportive communities, both inside and outside the prison walls.

Conclusion

This paper aims to systematically review selected research on higher education in prisons, focusing on how incarcerated and formerly incarcerated students experience learning,

which parts of these educational experiences they find most meaningful or transformative, and how structural, relational, and institutional factors impact access to and participation in these educational opportunities. Research shows that higher education in prisons has significantly benefited learners, promoted fairness, and supported reintegration into society.

Studies highlight numerous positive effects, including lower reoffending rates, improved career readiness, increased confidence, and stronger social bonds. However, these benefits are not equally accessible to everyone. Success often relies on stable funding, supportive policies, and strong institutional commitment. One of the main challenges is that, although prison education can be life-changing, access remains inconsistent and is often influenced by politics, funding, and economic conditions.

Another challenge lies in how research is carried out. Many studies rely on qualitative approaches and observational data that examine learners' personal experiences, providing valuable insights into how individuals develop, build resilience, and find purpose through education. However, fewer studies use quantitative or panel data methods, making it hard to measure the overall impact of prison education over time.

Equity remains a concern; only a small number of studies examine how factors like race, gender, disability, and language influence learners' experiences. This results in an incomplete understanding of how different groups are affected. Concepts like carceral capital, which could help programs better support learners, are not yet fully incorporated into research or program design.

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